when two rival Orientalists – the Madras civil servant Robert Sewell and Alexander Rea of the ASI – began their surveys in the late 1880s. In 1886 Sewell got to hear of curious remains said to have been built by the ancient Pandavas on a ridge midway between the lower reaches of the Godavari and Krishna rivers above a village called Guntupalle. He was delighted to find a line of rock-cut caves with decorated horse-shoe entrances very similar to those that Fergusson and Burgess had written about in the Maharashtrian country of the Western Ghats. Guntupalle proved to be the most southerly of the hundreds of Buddhist rock-cut caves mined to serve as *chaitya-griha*s (prayer-halls) for monks. Subsequent surveys by the ASI have shown that the first caves here were probably cut by Jain monks in the second century BCE under the patronage of Raja Siri Sada or Srisata, a successor to Raja Kharavela of Kalinga. The site had then been taken over by Buddhists at the time of the Satavahanas. They had enlarged the caves, reshaping one into a circular *chaityagriha*, turned the rest into cells with platforms for beds, and cut a flight of steps up to the top of the ridge, where they built a pillared assembly hall and a cluster of small stupas – all now neatly restored by the ASI.

Sewell criticised his rival Rea for not doing more at Guntupalle and in the Krishna Valley region generally. But Rea was being expected to cover an area that was enormous both in geographical and historical terms and had concentrated his resources on clearing and restoring the ‘lost’ city of Vijayanagara, spread over many acres of the south bank of the Tungabhadra River – better known today as the magnificently restored World Heritage Site at Hampi – which had been abandoned after its sacking by the armies of the sultans of Bijapur and Golconda in 1565. Mackenzie and his pandits had briefly visited the ruins back in 1799 but it was Rea and his small team who did the donkey work that made it possible for Sewell to write the ground-breaking